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LOS ANGELES

New laws trigger legal fight over Nazi-looted art

By Deepa Bharath
THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

LOS ANGELES — Jewish heirs of Holocaust victims and their representatives have filed two lawsuits in California staking their claims to Nazi-looted paintings that still hang on the walls of prominent museums in Los Angeles and Auschwitz.

This pair of lawsuits are the first to be filed after the recent passage of laws by California and Congress, which strengthen U.S.-based claims to artwork that were forcibly taken from Jewish families during World War II.

One lawsuit was filed in Los Angeles Superior Court on Monday by the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles and its board chair Daniel Gryczman against Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena for the return of "Adam and Eve." These are two life-size oil-on-panel masterpieces created by Lucas Carnach the Elder in 1530.

The other lawsuit was filed in federal court in Los Angeles the same day by the daughters of the late Dinah Gottliebova Babbitt, a Holocaust survivor and California-based animator who was held in Auschwitz. It demanded the return of watercolors of fellow prisoners that the artist was forced to paint for Josef Mengele, a Nazi physician who had earned the nickname the "Angel of Death."

Spokespersons for both museums say the museums legally hold titles to the works, and intend to continue displaying them to the public. The lawsuits don't specify the monetary value of the paintings.

ARTWORKS PIT JEWISH FAMILIES AGAINST MUSEUMS

The issue of Nazi-looted art is an emotional, legally and ethically charged topic that pits Jewish families that have suffered inter-generational trauma against museums that say they are trying to preserve a painful, yet important, chapter of history. Between 1933 and 1945, the Nazi regime orchestrated the largest art theft in world history, seizing over 600,000 works of art across Europe from Jewish families, collectors and museums. Decades later, many of these masterpieces reside in prominent museums around the world, making the push for their recovery more complex than a simple property dispute.

Rabbi Noah Farkas is president and CEO of the Jewish Federation of Los Angeles, the organization to which Marei von Saher, sole heir of Dutch Jewish art dealer Jacques Goudstikker, has signed over her rights. The paintings were seized from Goudstikker's collection by Hermann Goring, Adolf Hitler's second-in-command and changed a number of hands before being sold in the 1960s to the Pasadena Museum of Modern Art, which was renamed Norton Simon Museum in honor of its benefactor.

Farkas said the federation plans to use most of the net proceeds from the recovered art to provide much-needed help to the about 2,500 Holocaust survivors living in the Los Angeles area.

"These are incredibly beautiful European masterpieces stolen from a Jewish family to enrich the Nazi party and fund the war and death machine against the people," he said. "It's our honor to take on this role on behalf of the community and use most of the proceeds to help these elderly survivors live out the last years of their lives in dignity, comfort and peace — something their family members were denied during the Holocaust."

Marei von Saher, in a statement, said she is grateful to the Jewish organization for taking up her family's cause.

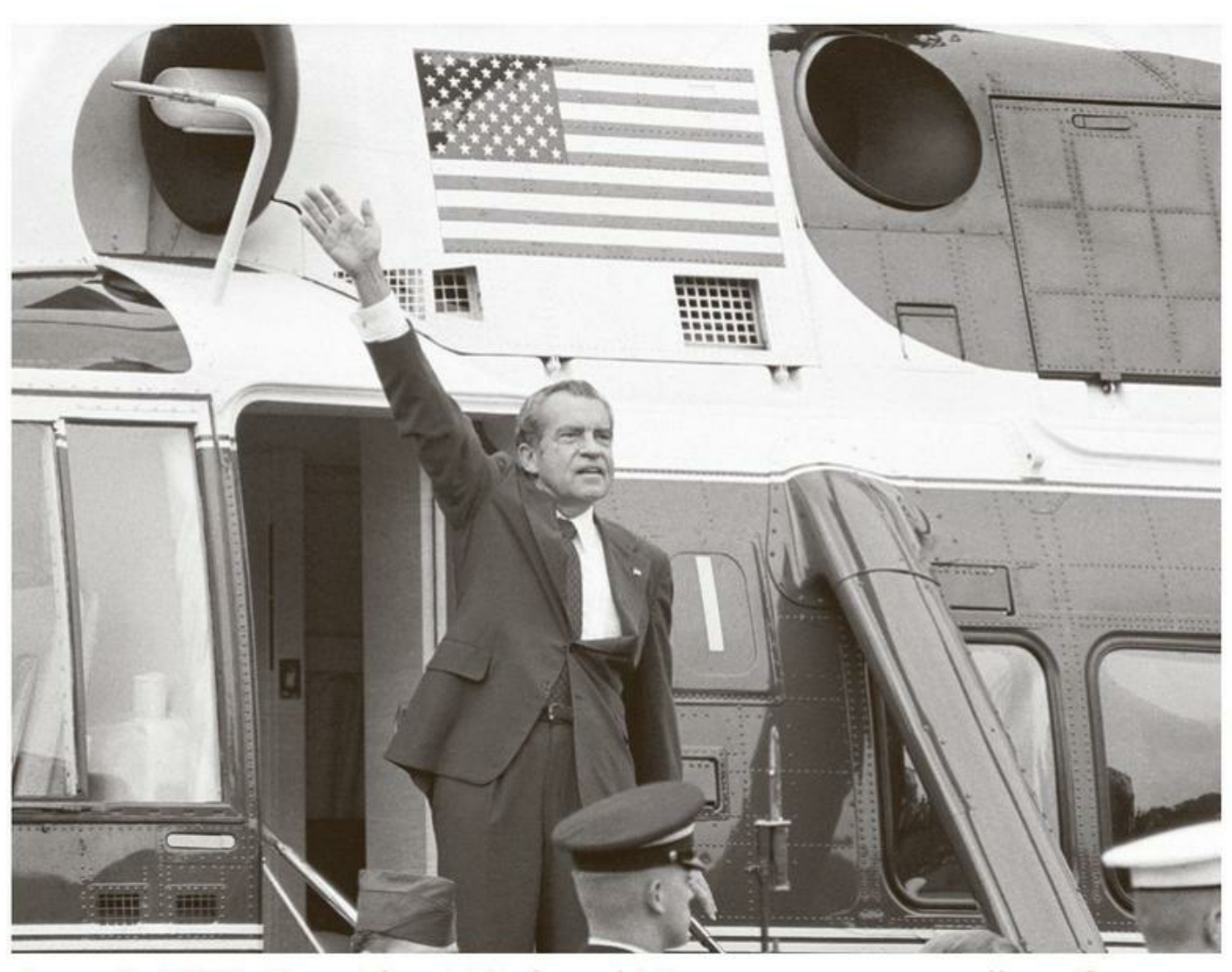
"This effort represents a meaningful step toward justice for Holocaust survivors and victims of Nazi era atrocities," she said.

NEW LEGISLATION GIVES LAWSUITS SECOND WIND

California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, wrote Assembly Bill 2867, signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in September 2024, which requires that the state law must apply in lawsuits brought by California residents or their heirs to recover art seized during the Holocaust or during other acts of persecution. Gabriel, who co-chairs the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, introduced the legislation in response to a federal court ruling, which allowed the state-owned Thyssen-Bornemisza National Museum in Madrid to keep a multimillion-dollar Camille Pissarro impressionist masterpiece.

Photographer Chick Harrity, documented history from Vietnam to the WH, has died

By Michael Weissenstein
THE ASSOCIATED PRESS


Aug. 9, 1974, President Richard Nixon waves goodbye from the steps of his helicopter outside the White House after delivering a farewell address to members of the White House staff. **CHICK HARRITY — THE ASSOCIATED PRESS FILE**

NEW YORK — Photographer Chick Harrity, who documented the Vietnam War and eight sitting U.S. presidents for The Associated Press and U.S. News and World Report, has died. He was 87.

Harrity took one of the best-known photographs of the Vietnam War, of a baby girl lying in a box alongside her brother in what was then the South Vietnamese capital of Saigon.

"Chick was an amazing photographer," said retired photojournalist Nick Ut, another AP Vietnam War photographer. "We all walked by this homeless boy near a woman selling cigarettes, but Chick saw the photo."

An eighth-grade teacher in his hometown of Reading, Pennsylvania, urged Harrity to pick up a camera, launching him on "a lifelong journey documenting the world around him," his wife of 51 years, Yvonne Henry, wrote in an online obituary.

HE TOOK PICTURES 'OF A GROUP OF PRETTY INTERESTING PEOPLE'

Harrity started his career in 1956 at a Reading newspaper and went on to spend 26 years at the AP, 13 of them in the Washington bureau. He then became chief photographer at U.S. News and World Report.

"I had the chance to run around the world taking pictures of a group of pretty interesting people. I was getting to witness history," Harrity said in his family's obituary.

As a member of the White House press corps for 33 years, he covered presidents from Lyndon B. Johnson to George W. Bush and was at the White House documenting Richard Nixon's resignation. One Aug. 9, 1974, photo shows a teary-eyed Nixon bidding farewell to members of the White House staff.

Harrity served in the Air National Guard and attended Kent State University. His hobby was "writing and photographing stories 'as a unit,'" the AP wrote in an internal article describing Harrity as the organization's Albany photographer.

Harrity had a great sense of comedy that imbued his work and personal lives, his wife said. "The guy had a fantastic sense of humor in every single part of his life," Henry said. "He always looked for something funny."

Obituaries

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Paula Randall Stark
June 28, 1952 - August 28, 2026
Yardley

Surrounded by love, Paula Randall Stark passed away peacefully on August 28, 2026, in Monterey, California, with her daughter, Carolin Remynse, holding her hand until her final breath. Following a courageous journey with Alzheimer's disease, Paula departed knowing she was deeply loved by her family.

Paula was born on June 28, 1952, in Fresno, California, the firstborn by only minutes of twin daughters born to Carolin Hansen Randall and Stewart "Denny" Randall.

Paula grew up with a love of family, community, learning, and adventure that remained with her throughout her life. She had great fun in Santa Cruz, spending many sunny days on the beach with family and friends. While attending the University of California, Berkeley, she was a member of Kappa Kappa Gamma, forming lifelong friendships and memories that she treasured throughout the years.

Paula made Monterey her home for close to five decades, building a life defined by family, friendship, and service to her community. She served as President of the Junior League of Monterey County and as President of FOCUS, the Friends of Carmel Unified Schools, generously giving her time and energy to causes that mattered deeply to her.

Above all else, Paula was devoted to her family. She was an unabashedly proud mother to Carolin Remynse and Ed Stark, and later found her greatest joy in her role as grandmother. Nothing brought Paula greater happiness than spending time with her grandchildren: Matthew, Annabella, Harrison, and Collette Schroeder, and her step-grandson, Jason Remynse Jr. She loved them not because of their accomplishments, but simply because of who they were. Her love was unconditional, unwavering, and constant. Her guidance, encouragement, and support shaped the lives of those closest to her and remain an enduring part of her legacy.

Paula also held a deep and enduring love for her brother, Stewart Denning Randall Jr., and treasured the bond they shared throughout their lives. She dearly loved her sister-in-law, Monica Randall, and took great pride and joy in her niece and nephew, Grace Randall and Stewart Denning Randall III.

Paula shared an especially close bond with her twin sister, Nancy Randall Boone. When they were younger, Paula and Nancy enjoyed many wonderful times and travels together, creating treasured memories filled with adventure and laughter. That loving connection continued through Nancy's children, Paula's niece Virginia and nephew William. Paula especially cherished hosting "Camp Lala" for them, creating joyful memories filled with love, laughter, and time together.

Paula was previously married to Edward Kevil Stark, with whom she shared her two children, Carolin Remynse and Ed Stark. She was later married to Jim Yates, who preceded her in death.

In her later years, Paula shared a cherished 16-year companionship with Michael Blas, one of the great loves of her life. She also developed a loving bond with Michael's sons, Stephen and Nicholas, who were always wonderful to her. Paula treasured the memorable cruises they took together and the warmth, kindness, and companionship they shared. She was deeply saddened by Nicholas's passing earlier in 2026 and held him close in her heart.

Paula and Michael enjoyed some of her happiest years together, sharing wonderful times with family and friends and creating memories around the world. Their travels included the wildlife preserves of Africa, the Amazon, Machu Picchu in Peru, Angkor Wat, and many other remarkable destinations. Paula regarded Michael as one of the finest men she had ever known and often compared his character, integrity, kindness, and strength to those she most admired in her beloved father, Denny Randall.

Although Alzheimer's disease gradually changed many aspects of her life, it never diminished the love she inspired in those around her. Her family finds comfort in knowing she is now at peace after a long struggle and reunited with loved ones who preceded her in death.

Paula was preceded in death by her parents, Carolin Hansen Randall and Stewart "Denny" Randall; her brother, Stewart Denning Randall Jr.; her former husbands, Edward Kevil Stark and Jim Yates; and Michael's son, Nicholas.

She is survived by her daughter, Carolin Remynse; her son, Ed Stark; her son-in-law, Jason Remynse; her grandchildren, Matthew, Annabella, Harrison, and Collette Schroeder, and Jason Remynse Jr.; her twin sister, Nancy Randall Boone, and Nancy's husband, Andy Boone; her sister-in-law, Monica Randall; her nieces and nephews, Virginia Sierra, William Giddings, Grace Randall, and Stewart Denning Randall III; her longtime companion, Michael Blas; Michael's son, Stephen; and many cousins and dear friends whose lives were enriched by knowing her.

The family would like to express heartfelt gratitude to the caregivers, healthcare professionals, and friends who provided compassion, comfort, and support throughout Paula's final years.

In lieu of flowers, remembrances may be made to the SPCA of Monterey County or Buyamba, where Paula sponsored the education of children in Uganda. www.ugandabuyamba.com

A memorial service will be held on October 9 at 11 AM at Sanctuary Bible Church, 8340 Carmel Valley Rd., Carmel, CA 93923

A reception will follow at noon at Kona Restaurant, 1200 Del Monte Center, Monterey, California 93940."

Paula will be remembered for her devotion to family, commitment to her community, adventurous spirit, and the love she shared so freely throughout her life. Her memory will continue to live on in the hearts of all who knew and loved her.

Mary Carolyn "MC" Hudgens
90 years
Carmel

Mary Carolyn Hudgens, affectionately known as "MC," passed away peacefully on August 23, 2026, at the age of 90.

MC was born and raised in Jonesboro, Illinois, to Cecil and Mabel Norris. She was the middle of three daughters, between her sisters Lenora, who preceded her in death, and Cecelia. She attended Northwestern University, graduating in 1957 with a degree in Speech Correction.

After completing her studies, MC turned her attention toward starting a family. She reconnected with her high school sweetheart, Glenn Earl Hudgens, and the love they had known in their younger years quickly blossomed again. In February 1960, at the age of 24, MC and Glenn were married, beginning a remarkable partnership that would span more than six decades. They were happily married for 63 years until Glenn's passing in December 2023.

MC and Glenn had four children, and in July 1972, the family relocated to Carmel, California. Although Illinois was where her life began, Carmel became her home, and she loved it so much that she remained there for the rest of her life.

While Carmel was home, MC had an adventurous spirit and an extraordinary love of travel. She explored much of the world, always looking for new experiences and places to discover. Her travels took her from Alaska to Antarctica and to Russia, Vietnam, Egypt, Africa, China, India, New Zealand, Australia, Iceland, and throughout Europe and the United Kingdom.

Many of her travels became treasured stories. In Iceland, she rode the native horses. She traveled to Australia to fulfill a childhood dream of holding a koala, and during her adventures in Asia, she had the unforgettable experiences of feeding a baby panda and a tiger cub. She also enjoyed numerous cruises that carried her to destinations around the world.

MC was also a true lover of all animals, and they remained a special and joyful part of her life. Horses were a lifelong passion for MC. She grew up with horses in Illinois, and her love of riding began in childhood and stayed with her throughout her life. In her later years, she returned to riding and continued well into her 80s—a wonderful continuation of something that had brought her joy since she was a young girl.

Above all, MC loved her family. She is survived by her children, Tom, Laura, and Brian. Her son Mark preceded her in death in 2006 from complications of diabetes. She is also survived by seven grandchildren, one great-grandchild, her sister Cecelia, and the many family members and friends whose lives she touched.

MC lived a long and remarkable life filled with family, love, adventure, curiosity, and experiences that took her around the world. She was deeply loved and will be dearly missed by all who had the privilege of knowing her.

In lieu of flowers, the family asks that donations be made in MC's memory to SPCA Monterey County, in honor of her lifelong love of animals.

CITATION (APA STYLE)

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